

Q&A: Detachment, Engagement, Motivation, Devotion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 1:04:22

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammāsbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa*

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Very good. Just before we start, we thought it would be nice to do the ceremony just after the carols, which is an option by the way, but it ends off with plain chant, so it's all very nice and peaceful. Is that all right? It means starting it just a quarter of an hour early, that's all. Instead of having a sitting at 14:30, I've given a bit more time after Christmas lunch, you see. And then instead of 16:15, if we make it at 16:00, then that still means we can have the old Christmas cake. And a special carrot cake, correct? Correct. Banana bread with peanut butter and poppy seeds, very good.

So here we go. I sometimes wonder if the practice is dulling rather than expanding my openness and appreciative joy. All these errors we can make in practice in this regard, such as creating an unskillful kind of detachment.

I think it's really being clear as to what the different practices are so that you yourself can balance your practice. *Vipassanā* has two functions. The first one is to purify the heart and the second one is to have insight. So the purification of the heart just happens naturally as you sit and all the stuff that we've suppressed or repressed or we're working with in daily life, all that just comes up. You can't avoid it – the turbulence comes up first. It's as simple as that. The lower depths of the ocean are nice and calm, you see, but what we're on is this horrible boat that keeps bobbing up and down on the storms of life.

So it is a case of recognising that a lot of our practice is allowing the heart to manifest its problems and recognising that so long as it doesn't slip into thought patterns, especially purposefully, they are actually dying out. And in time, they do give up. And the other thing to recognize or remember is that when you have, say, anger come up, it has an object. You're angry about something. But that's not the cause of it, remember. The cause is an internal decision to respond or react to a situation with anger. So therefore, the anger we have is really an internal attitude. I often use the word like a balloon of anger. And we let little bits of it out whenever something irritates. So it's not actually attached to the object. We can make it attached to the object.

I've just been talking to my nephew. He's studying music. So when you get this thumping music come

through the wall, it's us that decides it's annoying. And the more we decide that, the more annoying the music is, you see, right? So when we sit in meditation, although, shall we say, we'll talk about just anger, but any negative state, when it attaches to something, see, the idea is to come off the attachment that it's holding on to and go into the actual feel of it and to stay with the burn, whatever it is, right? It's exhausting its energy. It's not going anywhere. It's just coming out through the body as feeling. So that part of it is the purification and the really joyous thing about that is that although it is difficult, we don't have to do anything apart from attend. And if you think of the word attend to mean more in the sense of as a nurse might attend to a patient.

Did I send off that affectionate awareness in one of my e-reminders? No, okay. I've just written a little piece to send off. That's when you would bring a certain affection towards what it is that you are having to bear up with. And you're not trying to get rid of it with affection. You're not trying to change it with affection. You're just trying to regard it with affection. That's all. To regard it with affection. An affectionate regard.

What this does is it undermines the reaction of fear and irritation towards what it is that you're experiencing. So you get something come up like say anger and it comes up so much you're afraid of it, you pull off it, see. But when you actually approach the lion...I saw that film, oh dear, that cartoon thing that won the big prize, about a tiger, *Life of Pi*, see? So, the way he struggles with his tiger. It's funny that it should disappear once he landed, but we won't talk about that.

If you get that idea clear in your mind as to the mechanics, as to just the way the heart manifests its turbulence. It's we that put words on it. It's we that call it anger, fear and all that. Which then moves it into an area of conceptual understanding about our relationship to things. But actually in the body it's just feeling. And when it comes out as just feeling, it's healing. That's poetry.

So that's the first part. I'll be very clear about it. The other part is insight. And the insights are always to do with these three avenues of investigation. So when we say investigation you can actually say to yourself well in this sitting I'm going to try and be much more aware of how things come to an end. The impermanence of things. Or you can say this sitting I'm going to make a special effort just to see how the desire arises and how it attaches. Or you can say just in this period I'm just going to find that observation post within myself where I feel that everything is happening outside me as an object.

So these are your three avenues of investigation which liberate the knowing, liberate the Buddha within. Remember it's the way we're looking which is the delusion. Delusion doesn't arise in the mind itself. The delusion isn't in the mind itself as thought patterns and emotions and outside in ordinary life as our relationship, those are the manifestation of delusion. They are manifesting that we're looking at a situation in a wrong way. So that's your *vipassanā*.

Now, you'll note that in *vipassanā*, the seven factors of enlightenment do not include love, compassion, sympathetic joy. And there's a purpose to that. Because we don't want mental states, because they're only

mental states. They're not permanent. They arise and pass away. We don't want mental states to colour the way we're looking. We need this very clear, equanimous position in order to do the investigation. Which would be, say, quite normal to a scientist. I mean, that's what they're supposed to be doing. You're not supposed to be getting involved emotionally in anything that you're doing.

So then we recognize okay so how do you get to the pure, how do you get to love compassion and sympathetic joy? So remember that the purification that's going on in the meditation is releasing energy. The energy is not lost and in Zen they would say with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. You don't have to work at it. But generally speaking in Buddhist practice, you do have these practices, the practice of *mettā*, sympathetic joy and compassion, which are extending or reusing that energy which has now been released from its hold in anger and fear and all that. And you're using it to develop these better qualities. And the understanding is that there's no limit to how much of this energy you can actually create. Either way, I mean we call the immeasurables love, compassion, joy, but it's equally immeasurable how much fear and anger and horror we can develop.

So you've got to balance the practice with *mettā*, that's the thing, and you've got to balance the practice with sympathetic joy. It's taken me a long time to actually bring that into the routine of a *vipassanā* meditation. It was only last year that I finally got round to including sympathetic joy late in the evening. So that we begin in the morning with the practice of compassion where we bring to mind people who are sick and so on and so forth. And then in the evening we develop *mettā* and then sympathetic joy. So that there is this transformation going on.

So, in other words, the *vipassanā* isn't everything. The *vipassanā* is a specific technique to deal with specific questions. And again, that mental state of mindfulness that we are developing in *vipassanā*, which is, shall we say then, coloured with love, compassion, with an attitude, is something we're supposed to take into daily life. So that there's a continuity of this mindful awareness, mindfulness and awareness.

So that's it and how do we get through this unskillful kind of detachment? So the unskillful kind of detachment is when equanimity falls into its near enemy, its subtle enemy of indifference.

I've told this tale a hundred times, but maybe one of you haven't heard it, which gives me an excuse to say it all over again. Have you heard about my encounter with a monk and a mouse and a cat? Ah, right, good, there you go, I can tell my tale again for fear of boring everybody else.

So I went to visit this monk. I was in the monastery, so I had a chat with him. And there was a cat playing around with a mouse. So I said to him, did you stop that? Because the cat was fat. It wasn't a skinny. Often you get animals not being kept very well. But this cat was a fat cat. And I said, did you stop? He said, no. He said, it's cat *kamma*, mouse *kamma*. So he saw the whole thing happening. He was sat there and he saw the cat catch the mouse and then kill it and then just play around with it. He wasn't eating it.

Then not so long after that, I was in another monastery. And there were four or five of us sitting on a

bench. And it was the cool part of the afternoon chatting. And a cat suddenly jumped out and jumped on this bird. And one of the monks, as quick as lightning got up and gave this cat one hell of a kick. And then picked up the bird. And then realising it was dead, held it up and then he beautifully chanted: All compounded things arise and pass away. So of course his idea of what he should do when he sees something which is suffering is completely different from this other fellow you see.

So there for me that was such a stark contrast that has always remained in my mind as a distinction between those people who get into this quietism, I think that's what it might be called in the West, a sort of rejection of the world, a non-involvement, and considering that to be equanimity.

But of course we have the Buddha himself as an example. He didn't just sit under a tree once. He didn't just sit there in the bliss of his liberation. He got up and walked. I think it's about 300 miles from where he was, Bodh Gaya, all the way to Sarnath. Seemingly looking out for his old companions. So they must have told him where they were going or he must have heard where they were going or it was a regular thing that every year they turned up at Sarnath at this particular time of year. Because the ascetics at that time would do their rounds, you know.

And so, I mean, that's a great example. I mean, you know, he spent his time really cleaning out, cleaning himself up and then out he went. And it's difficult, if you look at the history of spiritual leaders, it's always the same, really, at the moment. You know, myself and Mike were doing this St. Francis thing. St. Francis, you see, one of his great big moments of, what would you call it, *metanoia*, that's the word, his conversion, was when he hugged a leper, which in those days was horrific. I mean, you just didn't do that, you kept them well away, you see. But somehow it reminds you of the story of Milarepa. You know, what was it? Can somebody remind me of that? Milarepa, do you remember that? He had a mangy dog or something and it turned into a bodhisattva. Do you remember that story? There you see.

So it's always this, you can't separate the world, the world we're actually living in, from the meditation itself, the inner world. You can't separate the inner from the outer world. You can't do that. Or if you do, then you end up in the error of creating this little island where there's just you being happy and everybody else is, well it's their problem, it's their *kamma*.

So I don't know whether anybody wants to make a comment on that, or add to it. Is the questioner happy with the answer? I don't know. Oh, he's impressed. Any matters arising?

I was going to buy a friend of mine a book, there's one in Waterstones called A Thousand and One Ideas That Will Change Your Life, this sort of thing. And so I read a few things that I know a little bit about just to test it, you know, and the one in Buddhism was interesting because they defined, and I'd be interested to know what you think about this, *Nibbāna* as self-centrism. Well, burn the book, it really is awful.

I'm now just reading a book by, interestingly enough, a Burmese. It's the Burmese really through the *Abhidhamma* who've tended to describe *Nibbāna* as a sort of oblivion. And the early Christian missionaries

didn't do much because they just saw it as annihilation, as a clever, as a very subtle form of annihilation. I don't know how you can make annihilation subtle. You're either here or you're not.

No, it's quite clear in the scriptures that there are two states. There's the one in which the Buddha nature, for want of a better word, is within itself. And that is described as boundaryless and full of light. It's a complete awakensness, but it is a totally enclosed thing. It's like, for instance, you were inside a light bulb without the glass. That's the sort of thing. But when that comes into the phenomenal world, which is through the psychophysical organism, and of course, it mirrors back to itself, through that organism, its view or its way of being with life. And therefore, the Buddha says, for instance, one person asks him, says, it's a regular quote, this training is very hard. He says, yeah, it's very hard, but then you reach *Nibbāna*. So he says, *Nibbāna*, so what? He says, well, when you get there, you are contented and with it happy. And that's the direct translation, *tutti suco a harati*. Contented, that's one of the big signs of somebody. Contentment just means this is the way it is. Whether it's painful or unpainful, one is at peace with it, one is at one with it, you might say.

So yes, you must give them that book, but write something in there that says, this is a lie. As to the greater understanding as to what happens to somebody who's fully liberated when they are reborn, then Theravāda tends to just say, well, it's *Nibbāna*. But the Mahāyana point out that that nature can re-manifest in the world in a beautiful form.

One thing that the book actually points to in this particular book I'm reading is that there's no overall clear definition of *Nibbāna* which would bring all the different sects together. They've all got their own little nuance on what *Nibbāna* is. But in Theravāda it's described both in a negative form. So for instance, it wouldn't be right, or it would be difficult to say that *Nibbāna* is happiness. Because as soon as you say happiness, you have an idea of what happiness is. And it's beyond ideation. It's not an emotion. There's no emotions in *Nibbāna*. It's not a thought. There's no thinking. There's not a feeling. There's no sensation. So as soon as you say happiness, you're stuck. So the Buddha prefers the negative. It's *adukkha*. There's no suffering. Which sounds really dry.

And when he talks about the actual experience in itself, then he talks about this consciousness which is boundaryless. So boundaries are only created by phenomena. Without boundary, not touched by any of the senses. So there's nothing phenomenal at all in there. There's nothing that arises and passes away. There's nothing that has any substance in our sense of the word. And in all directions full of light.

Is that what people refer to as emptiness? Yes. Well, emptiness, in our scriptures, there are two words, *anattā* and *suññatā*.

And in the Buddha's teachings, in our scriptures, he remains very, very centered on the individual, on you as a person who's suffering and how to get out of suffering. So there's no philosophy as such. There's no extension of that into any great philosophical concept, you might say. And the *anattā* draws you into yourself to ask, well, what is in me that is unchanging? What is it in me that is not suffering? And is there

something in me which I don't experience as a self, as something which is objective? If I look at my hand, my hand becomes an object. It becomes my hand.

The word *suññatā* simply means that, it's empty of all phenomena. Now later on in Buddhism as it got more philosophical, this concept was extended to all things. Everything is *suññatā*, everything is empty. Empty of substance, it arises and passes away, it has no existence as such. Although again, some schools say it exists at least for a moment. But I don't think that would be in our scriptures correct. It would be this constant swirl of energy which never substantiates, never holds. It's only the mind with its cognitive faculties that can actually hold an image long enough for us to actually see it as something which has some sort of substance to it.

I'm right in saying, get our mind out of that, these synapses in the brain and all that, they're all subatomic. What's happening in the brain? It's the energy there, the way it passes and stuff, electrical, isn't it? But isn't it all to do with little subatomic particles, the brain itself, when it's communicating? Molecules that are passed between the synapses, but they actually release electrical impulses and their manifest has just changed, there are changes in electrolytes, so it's like sodium and potassium changes. So it's at a molecular level.

But having said that, I think our understanding of the brain and of the mind is so superficial. It's beginning. Yes, exactly. So that's the level at which we're at at the moment. I'm sure there's more to it.

Now, I read somewhere about subatomic. The electron would be subatomic, wouldn't it? In the actual electric, yeah. You remember how our teacher was so keen on these little particles? Oh, *kalāpas*. That's right, yeah. That's why, yes. He used to say, well, that's where we get like the *kalāpas*.

In Abhidhamma, there are seventeen physical moments in a mental moment, seventeen mental moments in one physical moment. So when, for instance, a photon hits the back of the eye, for that to actually go to the first position of a percept, a single percept of that one photon takes seventeen thought moments. And these thought moments build up and build up on each other until finally you see a flower. So these little moments are called *kalāpas*. They're these infinitesimal time slots.

What I'm insistent on saying these days is, when you're very clearly in the position of the observer, of the feeler, of the experiencer, when you're actually there, and that position is very clear to you, that everything that you're experiencing is out there, outside the observer. When you come out of that position, just ask yourself, what was inside the observer? Because the observer, the feeling of self there, is a mirror image coming back into the knowing. We're very close to it. That's why the Buddha says, you know, those who are aware are in the presence of Nibbāna. He's actually pointing in the right way, looking back at it.

The example I usually use is of a mirror. So when you look in the mirror, it's your face you're looking at. But remember, it's the other way around. It's not actually how people see us. So in a way, when we get that

feeling of the observer within ourselves, there is a feeling of somebody watching, somebody feeling. Now that somebody is the face looking back at us. But it isn't what's looking outside of you.

No, but that's what I'm saying. Don't do that. What I'm saying is, just observe. Be in that position. Afterwards, reflect on, you see, what were the inner constituents of the knower.

I think that is the biggest conundrum, isn't it? The whole not-self. Well, I can't even start to... Well, I have written an amazing essay, which I will post on my e-reminder, which I hope makes things just a little bit clearer.

All the Buddha's saying is, if there is something in us which has the quality of what we would recognize as the spirit, it doesn't change. It is alive. It is awake. What is it? So all he says is, observe your experience at a physical level, at an emotional level, at a mental level, and ask yourself, is that it? And invariably you come up with the answer, no, it's not it. And then you begin to realise that there must be something that knows, that can see something changing, which can't be changing in itself at certain rates.

So it's a case of stepping back, not knowing where you're heading for. And you're heading for a cliff. And when you drop off, that's it. So you don't know what it is you're looking for, you're simply investigating what it is you're not. So that's the usual thing, *neti neti*, not this, not this.

Does that make a bit more sense? If you start looking at the observer, then you create another observer looking at the observer. It's a trick of the mind. You can't do that, you see. It's just being in the position of the observer that one begins to realise that, for instance, there's pain in my knee and there's somebody that knows it. Okay. That's enough. Now, you can actually go for the feeling of the observer. That won't create another observer. You have to go into the feel of the observer. Yeah, that's it.

Burn the book, by the way, man. Have a public burning. That's awful. It really is. Honestly, how they come up with these.

In the past years, I've felt that an increased awareness of sensations of fear and sadness and disgust has somehow reduced my engagement with life, reducing my willingness to undertake challenge. Not where I expect the path to take me.

Well, it depends what the original challenge was, you see. Often when we suffer from fear, we'll create challenges, you might say, in order to prove that we're above fear. It leads us to a sort of foolhardiness. Do you know what I mean? We create false challenges. Really motivated from a wrong attitude. Do you know what I mean?

When all those attitudes begin to calm, then our challenges are more realistic. And if no challenges come to us, what are we complaining about? I mean, does that make sense? You know, sometimes we, like for instance, a lot of people who get involved in the horror that's going on with climate change, on the surface of things, they are putting out this compassion for the world and spreading that gospel. Compassion for

the world. This is the world we owe it to our children. All that sort of stuff like that. But underneath it, they themselves might be suffering from tremendous fear as to that they themselves will be caught up in the holocaust. But they're not recognising that. It just stays there. And what it does is, it fuels it. It comes out in this peculiar way of overplaying your cards. One of the things is frustration and anger, you see.

So yeah there are things in my own practice that turns into concern for the self to such an extent that it becomes a hindrance in itself. It's not *mettā*, it just gets muddled and it's all fear. Exactly. I mean if you talk to a jihadist or somebody like that they would tell you that their motivations are perfectly wholesome and they would quote and all that stuff. And they would justify their anger. And then they justify their incredible cruelty to other human beings. Some of the reports are absolutely horrific. And it all comes from this underlying anger which is based on a fear.

What's the name of that writer? She's very good. The History of God. She wrote one on... Karen Armstrong. Yeah, Karen Armstrong. She did a study of fundamentalists in America. And what motivates them is fear. They really fear that modern society is undermining them. And I recently... If you see Google, it gives seasonal greetings. A seasonal festive greeting. It doesn't call it Christmas anymore. So I clicked on that. And there was an article in the Independent which said they'd done a survey in America where the society is split almost in half with those people who don't believe at all and those people who are all shades of belief. But the underlying progress is that those people from the age of, I think, sixteen, eighteen to thirty, it moves up to about sixty, seventy percent, I believe. So if you're a fundamentalist and you're seeing all these young people not coming in to church and whatnot. And that fear then, really, it turns, doesn't it? You attack the enemy.

I don't know where we're going. So I think if we feel, if we look back at our lives and we think, well, normally I would really go for this challenge, but now I'm not, that might be progress. You know, that might be... you'd have to sort of, a person would have to reflect upon it to actually see the situation as clearly as they could, and ask oneself, what does that situation demand of me? See what I mean? So there's more wisdom in that. Yeah, that you're not being driven by unconscious motives, unconscious motivation. I mean, we know all about that from Freud. He was excellent. He would have quite an insight into all that. The pathology of everyday life.

So, yeah. I suppose a tell-tale point might be when something is asked of us, which is testing, as you might say. And then we find ourselves able to rise to the challenge. That might be. Whatever it might be. It could be anything, couldn't it? It could be something out there. It could be personal illness, etc., etc. I just don't know. Any comments?

As the drives found by attachment dissolve, as the things that used to drive and motivate dissolve, where does action come from and how does one choose to do anything at all?

They have three types of *kamma* which remember in Buddhist terminology just means action. A *kamma* is an action. So you have this wholesome and unwholesome and then what they call functional. Functional *k*

amma.

So, normally speaking, so long as we have a self, there's always somebody doing something which is unwholesome or wholesome. And so long as we have a self, what we're trying to do is move over to the wholesome side. So remember that, that the Buddha also has psychology an inbuilt understanding of our psychology which is not to do so much with *nibbāna* as such but to actually make us happy within ourselves by working with these emotional states and developing the opposites so we're actually supposed to be getting happier in ourselves through the practice because you can't tell it on a direct line it goes up and down up and down but generally over say a period of five, ten years, what might I look back and think, well, I am generally more happy.

Now, you've got to be careful here. It might not be happy in an emotional sense, but more in a meaningful sense. Like your life is more directed, etc. So, it's a subtle thing. So, there is that, you see. So, as long as we have a self, you have to act. Just as soon as you get up in the morning, you're acting. There's always an intention in everything you do. So, there's an act. So, we're trying to develop our wholesomeness and letting go of our unwholesomeness.

Now when you're fully liberated and there's no self, the Buddha still gets up and acts. He still gets up and he feels hungry and he puts his robe on and he picks up his bowl and he goes off and goes for an alms round. Or he teaches. So he's always acting. In fact, occasionally he would go off by himself. He says for his own delight, his own happiness and as an example to others. But he seems to have led a very active life. I mean, you know, he was on call, on tap. He was always walking everywhere. He spent many a time. We know where he spent his rainy seasons. They tended to be between the two kingdoms of Magadha and, what's the other one called? Anyway, the two main kingdoms there.

So he was acting, but somehow they weren't wholesome or unwholesome. And all that's saying is that there's no self, it's not self-serving. Even when we do something wholesome, there's a bit of self-service. But when there's no sense of serving this imaginary self, and you are, as it were, in a direct, spontaneous communication, you know, with the people and nature around you and the world around you. And you see yourself as simply part of the flow of energies which are moving from one person to the other. And all you're doing through your understanding is helping the flow of goodness along. See what I mean?

There's nothing there which attaches and says, oh, this is me or this is not. I am finishing it off with, you know, I am teaching, I am this and that. It's just that, there's just that interconnection, a contingency, which happens spontaneously to somebody who's liberated. And for us, what we do is we just create little barriers, that's all. And stop the flow of energy. We draw it back into ourselves, for me.

So it doesn't, that's the whole thing about taking on the form of a human being is that it becomes a vehicle of expression whether it's negative or positive or in this sense neither negative nor positive see what I mean so it doesn't the process of liberation doesn't stop you from acting it just makes the acts more and more in direct communication with the way things really are. Not being perverted by self-regard. Having

said that, it's not as though the Buddha didn't take care of his body. So brushing your teeth is not... Yeah, brushing your teeth. It's not the same meaning you're serving the self. No. Yeah, you're taking care of your teeth. And considering they're the last lot we're going to have. So it is. Yeah, that's about it really.

I was also thinking of wording it as something like conventionally, day to day, we tend to think about meaning and I'm dedicating myself to X. That's right. But if that sense of meaning is dissolving, I think Adyashanti says that meaning is just another thing that the ego looks for, which is a very shocking statement in a way.

It depends. It depends. It's all to do with who the meaning is for. So if it makes me feel bigger and better and me feel stronger and more powerful, then it's obviously a meaning which is corrupting me. But if the meaning of my life is for the benefit of others flowing outwards, then I'm at the service. To give oneself to a service you must let go of yourself because you're at the demands of other people. So it's not that you forget your own needs but you're out there for other people. I mean that's the whole point of seeing service as a way of completely getting rid of the self.

In Zen understanding the best place to be is in the kitchen as a cook because there you have to feed all these different monastics and be aware of their little peculiar diets and what not. And make sure the food. And it's always for them, for them, for them. You eat. But you're actually doing it for them. So there's that sense of service. And that completely undermines the self. Which is always thinking about itself.

So. You know. I mean if I get. If somebody say. Wants an interview. When I'm happily engaged in this book. And I said oh bloody hell I've lost my sense of service my sense of service should be spontaneous as soon as somebody asks I'm out because that's what I've said I'm teaching now that doesn't mean to say that when I go on a personal retreat that I have to respond to that because then I'm looking after myself but as soon as I feel I've put myself out into the arena as a Dharma teacher then if any negativity comes up when I'm being asked to respond, that shows my sense of service is not yet purified.

Now, the peculiar thing is that the more you give yourself to others, or the more you give yourself to others not forgetting one's needs, the more the sense of self disappears. And the more the sense of meaningfulness grows. That's your paradox. Our sense of meaningfulness, the measure of our meaningfulness, is the measure of our commitment to something greater than ourselves.

It's interesting that the Buddha would say things like, "Who sees the *Dhamma* sees me, who sees me sees the *Dhamma*." So he had this tremendous respect for the *Dhamma*, for the way things are. And he serviced it completely, so that he could actually make that connection. Who sees me sees the *Dhamma* in action. And who sees the *Dhamma* also sees me. In other words, Buddha nature. How it ought to be.

So I don't know, Adyashanti might have been thinking of it in that more egotistic, more storytelling-like way. Maybe. But what you just said about authorship maybe helped me, because I had a very hard time when my book was published. Up to that point it was all about service, and then suddenly it became about

me, my name. And it was devastating because some of the interviews are about me and my skills and it was just awful.

But even that, you've got to be careful because remember there are three conceits. "I am better than," which is of course the usual one we think of. But "I'm worse than." See, that's a conceit. It's an inverted conceit, isn't it? An inverted pride. And the subtle one is "I am the same as." Because we group with people who are the same as us and other groups are either better or worse than us.

If when you were asked about your skills you had in mind just basically saying, "This is how I did it," I think that was my introduction. My foreword. But what I mean is, it was all about me being a vehicle and being a servant to that subject. And then suddenly, the world puts the spotlight on you. And you think, no, why are you looking at me? Look at it. So that was a big disappointment.

Well, we live in a society of celebrities. In the old days, you never put your name on work, did you? I need a pseudonym, I think. I'm seriously considering one.

In the introductory talk, you used the words "abiding in the present moment." It occurred to me, now this doesn't have the emotional punch, the Christian hymn, "Abide With Me." How will *Theravāda* ever make up the levels of emotional support that Christianity seems to offer?

That reminds me of someone who used to, well, she would define herself as a Buddhist. And she's a good meditator and she goes to Amaravati. But it was just too dry. She had to go along to a Christian church to get a bit of emotional oomph.

I think there's a deficit in the way that Buddhism comes to the West and in the way it's taught. When you go to the East you see that there's no deficit on the emotional side. It's to do with the way that we come to the practice. We come to the practice really to sort out our problems, to understand the world, and unwittingly we're not juicing it up with religious emotions.

That was one of the things about the carol service, you see, to try and see these emotional supports. And as you point out, Christianity is excellent at doing that. The music is so moving.

When my father died, I was in Sri Lanka at the time, and on hearing the news, I cried a little bit. But by the time I got back to my *kuti*, all that had gone, because I had a very good relationship with him, and he lived a good life, and I really was quite happy, and he died very quickly, there was no lingering. So I was fairly okay with it all, and I was with my mother in the church ceremony, and there's this hymn, I can't quite remember it, but it's the love of Jesus. As soon as it started, the tears are flowing down my face. It really cranked it up.

So music has this tremendous power to raise. And there's not much of it in *Theravāda* Buddhism. You're just chanting.

An interesting aside is that there was an orthodox monk in London, this is years and years ago, who led a

choir and he said it was so difficult to stop the choir singing emotionally. If you listen to plain chant, it's not emotional in the sense that it comes out of silence. In my humble opinion, ever since plain chant, there's been nothing but corruption.

So, if you consider what are the spiritual emotions, they're actually serviced in *Theravāda* if you want to do the exercises. The first one is a sense of gratitude. And by gratitude, just going through the Buddha's life and what he went through and what we've received from it, then every time you look at a Buddha statue, you just get this enormous gratitude. And that comes easy to Easterners.

There's a sense of awe. A sense of, when you realise what he achieved. And you realise the ineffability, really, of the *Dhamma*. The whole thing. Why we're here. All that is never really explained. How is it we're here in the first place? Where does this Buddha nature, where's it arisen from? There's a whole load of metaphysics which is just completely dark, and he never went into it, because from his point of view, it would just be inference. All we can know is what's within this bubble of awareness that we have.

And then there's praise, you see, and that's where you get the wonderful joy. If anybody goes to say one of the main shrines in Sri Lanka, or anywhere really, and you go along on a *puja* day, which is the full moon day of a month, I mean, you can slice the emotions like butter. And you can see people are completely in that seventh heaven of emotional bliss.

So in a sense, that's something that perhaps is instilled in you as a child, and that as you move into adulthood and you haven't got that, which a lot of young people now don't have. I mean, they've got all the music stuff, but they don't have these subtle religious emotions.

In my own case, I didn't really get into the emotional side of Buddhism until quite late. I would have been already fifteen years or so practising. And then slowly I began to see that I hadn't developed a heart relationship to the religion I had chosen. And as that came along, then I realised that's what I've got to do. And that's why I've got all these statues and *Kuan Yin* and a *stupa*. Because a *stupa* is really a tombstone. That's what it is. It's their representative of the Buddha's life.

And that's why I try to pop that, but not too much avail, I'm afraid. Because most people who come to the meditation really just want to sort themselves out. And I think that emotional value and the feeling of a heart connection with a religion we're in, grows in time. And having said that, brought up a Catholic, I walk into a Catholic church, I'm just back there, it's just beautiful, the feeling.

I went to what I think would be a Tibetan Buddhist service with a friend of mine in Seattle. But they were doing singing, they were using translated Tibetan texts, but to very westernised melodies. And that struck me as so artificial. It wasn't a pleasing, for me, it was not a pleasing solution. No sense of profundity. It didn't have the profundity of the chant or even the profundity of the western traditional.

It's very difficult, isn't it? I think Amaravati have done a decent job. If you listen to their chant, they chant in the Pali and they're in English. And it's still a chant. And I think they do it nicely.

People ask me why don't I do it here? But that takes, I need to know a musician and I mean, I'm happy with the Pali. Well, it's lovely. I thought the chant this morning, I really enjoyed it. It's a Burmese-type chant.

For about ten days after I left the retreat, back in the summer, every night it kept ringing in my ears. And it turned into a lullaby. And it was incredibly soothing and comforting. So I do think that's part of the process at some point. There has to be, I don't know about an emotional punch, but some heart connection. It becomes very dry.

The other way people do it is through the practice of *mettā*, of course. That's another way.

There's a reason it's making me think. I can't remember who she is. A contemporary Christian mystic. I just read a quote from her sometime this year, where she was saying, yes, her own path is difficult, but she has a hard time imagining the faith required to have faith in the present moment, if you will, like the Buddhists do, rather than faith in the judgement of Christ.

I think that's in part why religious Buddhism, as you're saying, in Southeast Asia, still does focus very much on the person of the Buddha. That is the human connection. It is a very personal connection. We're not very good in the West when it comes to complete devotion.

I'm remembering the movie, the documentary by Herzog. It is a pilgrimage to the biggest Dalai Lama gathering. The *Kalachakra*. Hundreds of thousands of people. Some people, it took them three and a half years. To not walk, but prostrating all the way. And they're all damaged now. And so they have measured the earth with their bodies. That's the kind of devotion and commitment in the West.

Well remember that's also to do with *kamma*. Either doing good *kamma* to undermine bad *kamma* or creating good *kamma* per se. But you're right, it is driven by this incredible devotion. It's lovely when you see it.

I suppose the unfortunate thing with the devotion approach is it moves rather easily into superstition. That's your problem with it. It has to be a balance.

The Buddha himself didn't like himself to be the object of adoration. Right there on his deathbed while he was dying, there's a young monk who looks at him with those glistening eyes, "*Bhagavān, Bhagavān*." He sends him off. Sends him off into the forest. "I don't want that, thank you very much."

So he wasn't personally into, and of course he didn't leave himself, he left the *Dhamma*. He was very clear about that. And as you know, for a very long time, he wasn't represented physically. It's always symbolic. The Greeks undermined all that, and I think later on too because of the very devotional aspect of Hinduism. I remember that Buddhism and Hinduism fenced each other for 1,500 years I think in India. So then there was this apparition of further Buddhas, all the Buddhas of the *Mahāyāna* which were really aspects of the Buddha turned into a Buddha. So the Buddha of compassion, the Buddha of healing, things

like that. I think that was all part of trying to contact the ordinary person, not the person who was an intellectual.

That was one of the criticisms of early Buddhism which began the split as early as 300 years after the Buddha's death, that it had become far too, the *Arahant* idea that you were just in it for yourself and you expected people to support you and you lived in your monastery like at Nalanda, thousands of them, and the disconnect with people. And I think that when they realised that they were losing ordinary people to a more emotional devotional approach, devotion started coming up with these things.

Now interestingly enough in the history of Sri Lanka when there was an attempt by a certain person to convert Sri Lanka to the *Mahāyāna*, he wrote a particular discourse which is called *Going to Sri Lanka — Lankāvatāra Sutta*. The monks from the main city, the old one, Anuradhapura. The capital of Sri Lanka, there were two big monasteries there, which created two different things. They left the capital and went south. And they told the king, his close advisor said to the king, "Look, if you don't watch it, you're going to have the *Mahāyāna*."

There were *Mahāyāna* monks and *Mahāyāna* temples. The *Mahāyāna* sculptures are there. And these *Theravādas*. So he decided on *Theravāda*. And he kicked all the monks out from the monasteries. All the *Mahāyāna* monks. But the practices of *Mahāyāna* — this devotion to the Buddha, offering flowers, all that sort of stuff — was all taken into *Theravāda*. That's where they think all the devotional practices of *Theravāda* came from. In my head it's quite late because maybe three or four or five centuries on. There's an article written by Onnit in the *Middle Way* if you're interested. I think it was the last one we got. It surprised me actually.

So it still had an effect on *Theravāda* Buddhism in Sri Lanka. And I think throughout, then throughout Burma and Thailand and all that, because you get lots of devotional practices there.

Just as a final thing, I was in Sri Lanka and I came across a group of women who were living as a community dressed in white and, in other words, on eight precepts. And they bunched their hair up into a bun, all of them. And they had a teacher guiding them. And in the shrine room, they had the Buddha statue, but every day they had a chair, and every day they offered slippers to the chair, to the Buddha, and water, and his pot of tea, and all that. They sort of set him up for the day. Incredibly sweet. I've never seen that before. They were very, very committed. Very good.

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